

# After your wisdom teeth

## RECOVERY GUIDE · THIRD MOLAR REMOVAL

Keep this guide handy  
Call our office with any questions

Wisdom teeth are more involved than most extractions — they sit deep in the jaw, usually require bone removal, and sometimes sit right next to a nerve. Your recovery will take a bit longer than a routine extraction, and the first few days can feel rough. That's normal. Here's what to expect and what to do.

| TODAY                                                        | DAYS 2–4                                                              | DAYS 5–7                                           | WEEK 2+                                                         |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Rest. Gauze. Ice. Soft, cool foods. Don't disturb the sites. | Peak of pain, swelling, and jaw stiffness. This is the worst stretch. | Noticeable improvement. Jaw loosens. Diet expands. | Mostly back to normal. Full tissue healing takes several weeks. |

### WHAT THE PAIN & SWELLING CURVE USUALLY LOOKS LIKE



## 1 The first 24 hours

### PROTECT THE BLOOD CLOT

A blood clot forms in each socket — it's your body's bandage. Losing it early is the main cause of "dry socket," which wisdom teeth are especially prone to.

- ✗ No rinsing, swishing, or spitting for 24 hours — let saliva gently drain
- ✗ No straws, no vaping, no sucking motions for 72 hours
- ✗ No smoking for at least 72 hours (longer is better)
- ✗ Don't poke the sites with your tongue or finger

### BLEEDING

Bite firmly on gauze for 30–45 minutes. Oozing and pink saliva for the first day is normal.

💡 **If bleeding restarts:** fold a fresh gauze (or a damp black tea bag — the tannins help) over the socket, bite firmly without checking for 30 minutes, and keep your head elevated.

### ICE FOR SWELLING

- 20 minutes on, 20 minutes off, for the first 24 hours
- You'll have "chipmunk cheeks" — this peaks at 48–72 hours, not the day of surgery
- After 48 hours, switch to warm moist compresses
- Bruising on the cheeks or neck is normal and can appear days later

### EAT SOFT, COOL FOODS

#### GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon only — no straw)
- ✓ Mashed potatoes, applesauce
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft pasta
- ✓ Lukewarm soup, broth

#### AVOID FOR AT LEAST A WEEK

- ✗ Hot temperatures (can restart bleeding)
- ✗ Hard, crunchy, chewy foods
- ✗ Chips, nuts, popcorn, rice, seeds
- ✗ Carbonated and alcoholic drinks
- ✗ Straws and spoons pressed into the sites

#### REST

Take 3–5 days off from work or school — ask us if you need a written excuse. No exercise, heavy lifting, or strenuous activity for at least 72 hours — elevated blood pressure can restart bleeding. Sleep with your head elevated on an extra pillow the first few nights.

## Days 2 through 7 and beyond

### WISDOM TEETH RECOVERY · CONTINUED

#### 2 Pain, swelling, and a stiff jaw

**Days 2, 3, and 4 are the peak.** After that, each day should be a little better than the last. A combination of **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** is as effective as prescription opioids for most dental pain — see your **Medication Guide** for dosing.

#### A STIFF JAW IS EXPECTED

Most patients can't open their mouth very wide for about a week. This is called **trismus** — the muscles around the surgical area tighten up from the surgery and swelling. It usually peaks on day 2–3 and slowly improves over 1–2 weeks. Gentle jaw-opening stretches after day 3 (without forcing it) can help.

#### 3 What's normal vs. what's not

##### NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ Peak pain and swelling at days 2–4, then daily improvement
- ✓ Bruising of cheek, jaw, or neck (can appear days later)
- ✓ Jaw stiffness limiting how wide you can open
- ✓ Yellow or whitish tissue in the sockets (healing, not pus)
- ✓ Slight bad taste or smell for a few days
- ✓ Slightly altered or "less sharp" sensation in lip, chin, or tongue that's gradually improving
- ✓ Food packing into the sockets (especially lower sites)

##### CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ Severe pain on day 3–5 that medication doesn't touch at all (possible dry socket)
- ✗ Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns *after* you'd started to feel better (possible infection)
- ✗ Bleeding that won't stop after 30–45 min of firm pressure
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ Numbness or tingling in lip, chin, or tongue that isn't clearly improving by the next morning — call right away if an area still feels completely frozen once the anesthetic should have worn off
- ✗ Jaw stiffness getting worse (not better) after day 5



**Is it dry socket?** If your pain medication brings pain down to a manageable level (around **2 or 3 out of 10**), it's *not* dry socket — you're on a normal healing curve. If the medication does **nothing at all**, that's the hallmark of dry socket. Call us; it's easily treated with a medicated dressing that brings fast relief.

💡 **Is it an infection?** Watch the *direction* of your pain, not just how much it hurts. After day 4, each day should be a little better. If you were improving and then the pain, swelling, or a bad taste suddenly comes back, that's the classic pattern for an infection. Call us.

**i Why do these happen?** Dry socket and infection are the most common complications after wisdom teeth — combined, they happen in roughly **15–30% of cases**, higher than simple extractions because wisdom teeth sit deeper and are harder to access. The mouth isn't sterile the way skin is; even with sterile instruments and careful technique, some patients still develop one. Both are usually straightforward to treat — call us and we'll take care of it.

**i About nerve sensation:** The nerves that give feeling to your lip, chin, and tongue sit close to the lower wisdom teeth. It's common for these areas to feel a little "off" or less sharp for a day or two — usually from nerve bruising, which almost always fully recovers on its own. What we want to know about — the same day or next morning, not later — is **complete numbness** (feeling like you're still frozen from dental anesthetic) that persists after the local anesthetic should have worn off, or altered sensation that isn't clearly improving day to day.

#### 4 Rinsing & hygiene (start tomorrow)

- Mix ½ tsp salt in 8 oz warm water. Rinse gently 3–4× daily, especially after meals.
- Let water *fall out* of your mouth — don't spit forcefully.
- If you have a plastic **curved-tip syringe** (we may give you one), start using it around day 5 to flush food out of the lower sockets. Aim low and away from the clot.
- Brush the rest of your teeth normally starting tomorrow. Avoid the surgical sites directly for 3 days.
- If you have a **chlorhexidine (Peridex) rinse**, continue it twice daily as you did before surgery; use saltwater the rest of the day.

#### 5 Other things that may help

- **Bromelain** (500 mg, 3× daily, 5–7 days) — a pineapple-derived enzyme with research support for reducing swelling and speeding recovery after oral surgery. Skip if you take a blood thinner, have a bleeding disorder, or are allergic to pineapple.
- **Sleep** — 7+ hours a night. Sleep loss measurably slows healing.
- **Protein** — aim for 80–100g daily. Soft options: Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, eggs, protein smoothies (spoon only).
- **No nicotine or cannabis smoke** — smoking, vaping, or nicotine pouches significantly increase the risk of dry socket and delay healing. Avoid completely for at least 72 hours; a week or more is better.
- **No alcohol for at least 72 hours** — interacts with medications and slows healing.

### When to call us

- Severe pain on day 3–5 that your medication doesn't help at all (possible dry socket)
- Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns after you'd started to feel better (possible infection)
- Heavy bleeding that won't stop after 30–45 min of firm gauze pressure
- Swelling spreading to your neck or around your eye
- Fever over 101°F
- Numbness in lip, chin, or tongue that isn't clearly improving by the next morning
- Jaw stiffness getting worse (not better) after day 5

### URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck, under your tongue, or around your eye

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

*Wisdom teeth recovery can feel worse than expected around days 2–4 — you're not alone, and it doesn't mean anything is wrong. If something doesn't feel right, call us.*